

MONCHO UNSCHOOLING

# Baseball

## Unit Study

*“Step up to the plate and discover that every pitch, swing, and slide hides a secret about science, numbers, words, and people.”*

Math | Physics | Language Arts | History | Geography | Art & Creativity | Movement & Body | Critical Thinking | Life Skills & SEL | Music

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🧭 **How to use this guide:** This is not a workbook, and there's no answer key — on purpose! Every challenge is an invitation. Pick the ones that spark curiosity, skip the rest, and go find the answers by doing. **AI plans. Kids DO.** 🚀

# ⚾ MATH

*Baseball is secretly a math game, played on a field built from exact distances, angles, and numbers.*

## 🏟️ Challenge 1: Build a Mini Diamond

🎯 Scale and Measuring

***How can you squeeze a giant ballfield into your backyard without changing its shape?*** ❓

On a Major League field, the distance between bases is 90 feet (about 27.4 m), and the pitcher's mound is 60 feet 6 inches from home plate. You'll shrink it with a scale: 1 foot becomes 1 inch.

1. Cut a string 90 inches long. That's one basepath at your scale.
2. Lay a piece of chalk at home plate. Stretch the string to mark first base, then turn a square corner and mark second, third, and back home.
3. Use a ruler to mark the mound 60.5 inches from home plate, along the line from home to second base.
4. Run the bases, counting your steps for each side. Do all four sides take the same number?
5. Chalk in the bases, the mound, and home plate.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use a 1 foot = 1 inch scale only for the basepaths, and skip the mound.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Switch to a scale of 1 foot = 2 inches. How long is each basepath now, and how many steps do you take?

## 🧮 Challenge 2: Who's Hot? Who's Cold?

🎯 Division and Decimals

***How can one little number tell you which batter is having the best week?*** ❓

You're the team statistician, and the coach wants to know who's hot. A batting average is hits divided by at-bats, written as a decimal with three places.

1. Copy this table onto paper:
2. Divide hits by at-bats for each player. A calculator is fine, or try long division.
3. Round each answer to three decimal places. (For example, 6 ÷ 20 = 0.300.)
4. Rank the players from highest to lowest average. Mark anyone at .300 or higher as hot, and anyone below .250 as cold.
5. Write all four averages on a scorecard, in rank order.

Maya: 6 hits, 20 at-bats

Leo: 9 hits, 24 at-bats

Sam: 4 hits, 16 at-bats

Ava: 10 hits, 25 at-bats

Why: Dividing turns different numbers of at-bats into one fair scale. That's how a player with 16 at-bats can be compared to one with 25.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use players with 10 or 20 at-bats only, so the division is easy.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Maya gets 4 more at-bats and 2 more hits. What's her new average, and does she move up in the ranking?

## 📐 Challenge 3: Cut the Plate

🎯 Angles and Shapes

***Why does home plate have a pointy end instead of being a plain square?*** ❓

Home plate is a five-sided shape, which looks like a square with two corners cut off to form a point. Build one and measure it.

1. Cut a square of paper, about 6 inches on each side.
2. Mark a point halfway along the bottom edge, and mark the middle of each side edge. Draw a line from the bottom point to each side mark, then snip off the two bottom corners.
3. Check your shape. Count five sides.
4. Use a protractor to measure all five angles. Write each one inside its corner.
5. Add up the five angles. Is the total 540°?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Measure only the two top angles, which are still square corners from your original paper.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Find the angle of the point at the front of the plate. Then cut a second plate that is twice as big and check whether the angles change.

# ⚾ PHYSICS

*Every pitch, roll, and swing in baseball is really a small physics experiment happening right in front of you.*

## 🏃 Challenge 1: How Fast Is a Toss?

🎯 Measuring Speed

***If you can barely time a gentle toss, how could anyone catch a ball flying much faster?*** ❓

1. Use a tape measure or count big steps to mark two lines on the ground about 20 feet apart.
2. Stand on one line while a partner stands on the other with a glove or soft hands.
3. Toss a soft ball underhand toward your partner. Use a timer or stopwatch to time it from your hand leaving the ball to the catch.
4. Do 5 tosses. Write the distance and each time in a notebook.
5. Now think: a Major League fastball is thrown around 90 to 95 miles per hour (about 145 to 153 km/h) and crosses 60 feet 6 inches in well under half a second. How many times longer did your toss take than that pitch?

Why: speed is distance divided by time. A fast pitch covers a long distance in so little time that the batter has barely a blink to decide.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use a distance of 10 feet and time just 3 tosses, counting out loud "one-Mississippi" instead of using a timer.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Toss from 10, 20, and 30 feet and divide the distance by the time for each. Does your toss speed change when you throw from farther away?

## 🌱 Challenge 2: Groundskeeper's Roll Test

🎯 Friction

***Why does the very same ball stop sooner on some ground than on others?*** ❓

You're the groundskeeper, and you need to know which surface lets a ground ball roll the farthest.

1. Find three surfaces: grass, carpet, and pavement (a sidewalk or driveway works).
2. Roll the ball down a small ramp, like a board or thick book leaning on a step, so every roll starts the same way.
3. Mark where the ball stops each time with a piece of chalk or a shoe.
4. Roll it 3 times on each surface and measure how far it traveled.
5. On a notebook page, sketch each surface up close and write which one slowed the ball the most.

Why: friction is the rubbing force between the ball and the ground. Rough, bumpy surfaces grip the ball more and steal its motion faster.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Test just two surfaces, grass and pavement, and use your own steps to measure how far the ball rolls.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Predict the order of the surfaces from shortest roll to longest before testing. Then try a wet patch or a dusty patch and see how it changes the results.

## 💥 Challenge 3: Heavy Stick, Light Stick

🎯 Mass and Force

***Would a heavier stick send a ball farther, or would it be too hard to swing fast?*** ❓

1. Hang a soft ball from a tree branch or a doorway using string, so it sits at about hip height.
2. Grab a lightweight stick (like a cardboard tube or pool noodle) and a heavier one (like a broom handle).
3. Swing the light stick at the ball as hard as you comfortably can. Mark with chalk where the ball lands.
4. Swing the heavy stick the same way and mark where that ball lands. Repeat each one 3 times.
5. Draw a chart on the pavement in chalk showing where each swing's ball landed.

Why: a heavier stick packs more push into the ball, but it's harder to swing quickly. Hit distance depends on both the stick's mass and how fast you swing it.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Do just one swing with each stick and say out loud which one felt easier to swing and which one made the ball move more.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Try choking up by holding each stick closer to the middle and see how that changes how fast you can swing and how far the ball goes.

# 📖 LANGUAGE ARTS

*Baseball is full of strange words, famous songs, and big voices, and you get to play with all of them.*

## 📚 Challenge 1: The Baseball Dictionary Editor

🎯 Word Origins

***Why would anyone call a place where players sit a "dugout" or a "bullpen"?*** ❓

You're the editor of a brand-new baseball dictionary, and you need at least 10 odd words to fill it.

1. Make a list of 10 or more baseball words that sound strange, like bunt, dugout, bullpen, shutout, pinch hitter, or fly ball.
2. Research each one: ask a grown-up who knows baseball, look in a library book, or search a kid-friendly dictionary for where the word came from.
3. Write each entry on its own index card or paper strip: the word, what it means, and why it got that name. Put the cards in ABC order.
4. Add a small drawing next to every entry, then staple or tie your cards together.

Why: Many baseball words began as everyday words people stretched to fit the game, so the name often tells a little story about where it started.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick only 5 words from the examples and write one sentence for each meaning. Skip the research and guess why it got its name, then check your guess with a grown-up.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a pronunciation guide, a part of speech (noun or verb), and a sentence using each word. Then write one new word of your own and invent a fake origin story for it.

## 🎵 Challenge 2: Your Backyard Verse

🎯 Rhyme and Rhythm

***How can you squeeze your own game into a song that everybody already knows?*** ❓

"Take Me Out to the Ball Game" was written in 1908 by Jack Norworth and Albert Von Tilzer, and neither of them had seen a game when they wrote it. If they could write a baseball song without watching a game, you can write a verse about the one you play.

1. Sing or hum the verse you know, and tap out the beat on your knees.
2. Brainstorm: who plays in your backyard game? What do you use for bases? Who always argues about the rules?
3. Write 4 lines about your own game. Match the beat of the original, clapping each line to count the syllables.
4. Make the second and fourth lines rhyme, then sing it all the way through and fix any line that trips you up.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Keep the first two lines of the song the same and change only the last two, filling in your own words.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Write a second verse and a chorus, so your song has a beginning, a middle, and an ending. Teach it to a friend or family member and sing it together.

## 🎙️ Challenge 3: Call the Inning!

🎯 Descriptive Writing

***How do you make a listener who can't see the field feel every pitch?❓***

You're the radio announcer, and the people at home are counting on you to paint the whole picture with words.

1. A game has 9 innings. Each inning has a top half and a bottom half, and a team makes 3 outs in each half. Choose one half-inning to call.
2. Invent two teams and a few players with fun names.
3. Write a play-by-play on paper: the pitch, the swing, the catch, and each of the 3 outs. Use strong action words like blasts, snags, and zooms, and describe sounds and crowd noise.
4. Read it aloud like a real announcer, with a big voice, quick bursts when the action heats up, and a long pause before the final out.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Write only 5 or 6 sentences, one for each moment, and read them with an announcer voice.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Record yourself reading it on a phone. Then add crowd sounds made by family members, and a "color commentator" partner who adds funny facts between pitches.

# 📜 HISTORY

*Baseball's past is full of brave people and big ideas that changed the game and the country, and you get to investigate them.*

## 📮 Challenge 1: A Letter to Number 42

🎯 Historical Empathy

***What would it feel like to watch someone change history right in front of you?*** ❓

You're a young fan sitting in the stands in 1947. On April 15, Jackie Robinson walked onto the field for the Brooklyn Dodgers and broke Major League Baseball's color barrier. Today his number 42 is retired across all teams, and every player wears it only on special Jackie Robinson Day.

1. Find a library book or kid-friendly website about Jackie Robinson and write down 3 things he faced in his first season.
2. Decide what you, as a fan in 1947, would want him to know.
3. Take a clean sheet of paper and write him a thank-you letter in your best handwriting.
4. Sign it with your pretend 1947 name.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Write just 3 sentences: one thing you noticed, one thing you admire, and a thank-you.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a postscript with a question you'd ask Jackie if he could write back, then write the answer you imagine he'd give.

## ⚖️ Challenge 2: Two Leagues, Two Stories

🎯 Seeing Both Sides

***Is a place made just for you always a gift, or can it be a wall too?*** ❓

In 1920, Rube Foster started the Negro National League. It gave Black players a place to play professionally, because the major leagues did not let them in. Now your family gets to weigh what that meant.

1. Learn the facts together: read a short article or book about Rube Foster and the Negro Leagues.
2. Split into two teams. Team A argues that a separate league was needed and helped. Team B argues that separate leagues also meant something was lost.
3. Each team gets 3 minutes to make its case, then 1 minute to answer the other side.
4. On a sheet of paper, draw two columns and list the points each side made.
5. Trade sides and try again, so everyone argues the other view.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the timer and take turns giving just one point each, with a grown-up writing down the list.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a third column titled "What I still wonder" and find one real fact that answers one of your questions.

## 📖 Challenge 3: Write the Rules

🎯 Rule Writing

***Why would anyone need to write down the rules of a game everybody already plays?*** ❓

Long ago, kids and adults played bat-and-ball games that were a little different in every town. Then, in 1845, Alexander Cartwright and the New York Knickerbockers wrote down early rules, and the first recorded match under those rules was played in Hoboken, New Jersey, in 1846.

You're the league commissioner of a brand-new backyard game.

1. Pick a ball, something to hit or throw it with, and a few markers like shoes or cushions.
2. Invent a game, play it for 5 minutes, and notice where arguments pop up.
3. Write exactly 5 clear rules that stop those arguments.
4. Test your rules with a friend or family member and fix any rule that confused them.
5. Copy your final rules onto a fresh page with a title and your signature.

Why: Written rules mean everyone plays the same game, so a match in one town can be fair against a team from another.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Write 3 rules instead of 5 and draw a picture of the field layout.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Trade rulebooks with another player, play their game exactly as written, and note which rule needed the most fixing.

# 🗺️ GEOGRAPHY

*Baseball is played in cities and countries all over the world, and a map can show you where its biggest stories happen.*

## 🧭 Challenge 1: Plan a Dream Baseball Road Trip

🎯 Map Reading

***If you could only visit four baseball places in one summer, which route would make the best trip?*** ❓

You're the road-trip planner for a baseball-loving family. Grab a big sheet of paper, a pencil, and a US map (a paper atlas or a free online map).

1. Find Boston, Chicago, Cooperstown, and South Williamsport on the map.
2. Mark each one with a dot and write its name beside it.
3. Pick a starting city and connect the stops in the order you'd visit them.
4. Plan your timing so you reach South Williamsport, Pennsylvania in August, when the Little League World Series is held there every year.
5. Draw a compass rose in one corner and add a small baseball icon at each stop.

Why: Mapmakers use a compass rose so anyone who reads the map agrees on which way is north, south, east, and west.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Plot only two stops, Boston and Chicago, and use a ruler to draw one straight line between them.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a legend with a different symbol for each stop, and rank your stops from closest to farthest from your own home.

## 🌏 Challenge 2: Three Countries, Three Ways to Cheer

🎯 Countries and Cultures

***How can one game feel so different when fans in three faraway countries cheer for it?*** ❓

Baseball is the national sport of countries including Japan, Cuba, and the Dominican Republic, where it is very popular.

1. Find all three countries on a globe or map and mark them with a sticky note or small dot. Notice which ocean or sea each one touches.
2. Ask a grown-up, a librarian, or a friend from one of these places how fans there enjoy a game. You can also look at library books or a kid-friendly travel website. Write down one snack or tradition for each country.
3. Make three index cards, one per country, with the country's name, a tiny map sketch of where it sits, and the snack or tradition you found.
4. Lay the cards side by side. What is the same? What is different?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make cards for just two countries, and draw a picture of the snack instead of writing about it.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a fourth card for your own country or hometown, then circle one tradition your whole group would want to try.

## 🏟️ Challenge 3: Who Owns the Stadium Sky?

🎯 Satellite Maps

***Why would anyone build a baseball field in a funny shape instead of a perfect one?*** ❓

Open a free map tool like Google Earth or OpenStreetMap and fly over Fenway Park in Boston and Wrigley Field in Chicago.

1. Zoom in on each park until you can see the outfield walls, the streets hugging the park, and the buildings crowded next to it.
2. Spot what sits right behind left field at Fenway. Its famous left-field wall, the Green Monster, stands tall partly because the park had to squeeze in beside a street.
3. Compare it with Wrigley's neighborhood. What streets and buildings surround it?
4. On paper, sketch one ballpark's walls, the nearby streets, and one quirk the surroundings caused.
5. Pick a spot near your home, like a yard, park, or empty lot, and sketch where a diamond could squeeze in. What would be in the way?

Why: Cities grew up around old ballparks, so streets and buildings that were there first decided where the walls could go.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Study only one ballpark and draw just its walls and the closest street.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Measure your home spot by pacing it out, then guess how many of your steps would fit between home plate and the outfield wall.

# 🎨 ART & CREATIVITY

*Baseball isn't only a game to play, it's a world to design, from the walls around the field to the stitches on the ball.*

## 🏟️ Challenge 1: Design Your Dream Ballpark

🎯 Imaginative Drawing

***What would make a ballpark so special that people could recognize it from just one wall?*** ❓

You're the stadium architect, and a city has asked you to design its brand-new ballpark. With a grown-up, look up photos of Fenway Park's towering Green Monster and Wrigley Field's ivy-covered brick walls. Notice how one big feature makes each park unforgettable.

1. Sketch the shape of your field in pencil on a big sheet of paper.
2. Invent a signature wall feature, like a waterfall, a hedge maze, a giant mural or a slanted hill.
3. Add seats, light towers and a scoreboard.
4. Color it in and give your ballpark a name.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the full stadium and draw only the outfield wall, with one wild feature and a name for it.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Draw a second view from high above, like a bird's-eye view, and mark where your signature feature sits.

## 🎨 Challenge 2: Backyard Team Brand

🎯 Logo Design

***How can a few colors and one picture make a team feel like a team?*** ❓

Every team has a look that says "this is us." Now it's your turn to invent yours.

1. Pick a team name and a mascot, like a lizard, a comet or a taco.
2. Choose two or three colors and write one reason for each, such as "red for energy."
3. Sketch three different logo ideas, then circle your favorite.
4. Draw a player wearing your uniform, with the logo on the cap and the jersey.
5. Color it in and add a number on the back.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick just one color and one shape, like a circle or a star, to build your logo around.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Design a second, away uniform in new colors that still feels like the same team.

## ⚾ Challenge 3: Stitch a Baseball

🎯 Sculpting & Pattern

***Why do the red stitches on a baseball loop around instead of running in straight lines?*** ❓

A baseball has 108 double stitches holding its leather cover on. Time to build your own model and trace that looping path.

1. Roll a lump of air-dry clay or wadded paper into a ball about the size of your fist. If you use paper, wrap it in strips of tape or glued newspaper so it's smooth and firm.
2. Let it dry or harden, then paint it white.
3. Use a pencil to draw two curved lines that wiggle around the ball like the seams on a real one.
4. Paint short red stitches along both lines with a thin brush or a cotton swab.
5. Turn the ball slowly and follow the red path with your finger.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Paint only 20 stitches instead of all 108, spacing them evenly along the curve.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Count your stitches in groups of ten as you paint, and see how close you can get to 108.

# 🏃 MOVEMENT & BODY

*Baseball is a full-body sport, and every sprint, throw, and wind-up asks your muscles to do something different.*

## 🏃 Challenge 1: Lap Time Lab

🎯 Body Control

***Does running around the bases wide or tight change how fast you get home?❓***

Mark a small diamond in your yard or a park with four flat objects (shoes, bean bags, or paper plates) as bases, spaced 10 big steps apart. Ask a helper to time you.

1. Run one lap, swinging wide around each base, and have your helper time it.
2. Rest and drink some water.
3. Run another lap, cutting each corner tight, leaning into the turn and touching the inside of each base.
4. Try a third lap, changing how you pump your arms or where you look.
5. Write each time in a log and add a note about how each lap felt in your legs and on the turns.

Why: When you take a wide turn you travel a longer path, and a tight turn lets you stay close to a straight line. Leaning in helps your body turn without losing speed.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Run just two laps, wide and tight, and compare which one felt faster before checking the times.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Run each style three times and use the middle time for each, so one slip or stumble doesn't fool you.

## 🧤 Challenge 2: Back-Step Catch Challenge

🎯 Throw and Catch

***How far apart can two people get and still catch every throw?*** ❓

Grab a partner, a soft ball (or rolled-up socks), and an open space. Stand about 5 big steps apart to start.

1. Take turns throwing the ball underhand or overhand, so both of you get to throw.
2. When you each catch a throw without dropping it, one of you takes a big step back.
3. Keep going until a throw is too far or someone misses twice in a row.
4. Count the steps between you at the farthest successful catch.
5. Write down your personal best, then try again another day and see if you can beat it.

Why: A longer throw needs your whole body, with your legs pushing, your hips turning, and your arm following through, not just your arm alone.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use a bigger, softer ball and start close, moving back only after two catches in a row.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Catch with only your non-throwing hand, or add a quick spin before each catch.

## 💃 Challenge 3: The Wind-Up Dance

🎯 Balance and Flexibility

***Which muscles wake up when a pitcher winds up and lets go?*** ❓

You're the pitching coach, and your job is to teach a pretend pitcher a wind-up dance.

1. Start with 3 slow stretches: arms overhead, a side bend, and a gentle twist.
2. Add a balance pose, like lifting one knee and holding still for 3 seconds.
3. Step forward and swing your arm through in a smooth follow-through.
4. Link everything together and practice it a few times, adding your own style.
5. Pay attention to which muscles feel it: legs, belly, shoulders, or back.

Why: A pitch starts in the legs and core, and the power travels up through the body to the arm. Balance keeps your body steady so the throw goes where you aim.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use just two moves, one balance pose and one follow-through, and hold each for a slow count.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add music with a steady beat and make your routine match it, ending with a freeze pose.

# 🧠 CRITICAL THINKING

*Baseball is full of big claims, sneaky arguments, and amazing streaks, and a good thinker knows how to test every single one.*

## 🕵️ Challenge 1: Prove It With Evidence

🎯 Evaluating Evidence

***When someone says "the greatest ever," how can you tell if they have proof or just a loud voice?*** ❓

Baseball is packed with big claims like "Babe Ruth was the greatest slugger ever" or "A fastball is hard to hit." Time to play detective!

1. Pick one claim. Try the Babe Ruth one: he hit 714 career home runs. Is 714 proof of "greatest"? What else would you need to know?
2. Ask three questions: Who said it? What numbers back it up? What numbers might argue against it?
3. With a grown-up, visit a free stats site like Baseball-Reference. Hunt for one fact that supports your claim and one that complicates it.
4. Draw a two-column evidence board: Supports on the left, Pushes Back on the right.
5. Finish with one sentence that starts "I'm this sure because..."

Why: strong evidence can be checked by someone else, and one big number rarely tells the whole story.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick a claim from your own life instead, like "our dog is the smartest," and list just one thing for each column.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Test a second claim and compare: which one had stronger evidence, and why?

## 🪙 Challenge 2: Spot the Sneaky Argument

🎯 Spotting Persuasion Tricks

***If a team has lost five games in a row, is it really "due" for a win?*** ❓

Sports talk is full of persuasion tricks. Let's catch them in the wild!

1. With a grown-up, listen to a few free radio clips or YouTube highlights, or read a newspaper sports page. Collect three tricks, like "everybody knows...," "he always chokes," or "this team is due."
2. Test the "due" idea. Flip a coin ten times and write down each result in order (H or T).
3. Circle every streak of two or more in a row. Did tails "owe" you a heads after a streak?
4. Write your own sneaky sentence, like "Everybody knows the home team always wins on Fridays," and trade with someone. Can they find the trick hiding inside?
5. Make a Field Guide page with your three tricks, an example of each, and your coin-flip tally.

Why: a coin has no memory, so each flip is a fresh 50-50 no matter what came before.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Collect just two tricks and flip the coin five times.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Flip 30 times and compare your longest streak to a friend's. Who had the longer one, and does it prove anything?

## 🔥 Challenge 3: What Makes a Streak?

🎯 Analyzing Causes

***What would it take for you to show up, ready to go, thousands of days in a row?*** ❓

Cal Ripken Jr. played 2,632 consecutive games for the Baltimore Orioles, ending the streak in 1998. That is incredibly rare. Let's figure out why.

1. Think about why such a streak is so hard to keep. What could get in the way of showing up that many times?
2. Brainstorm what it takes to keep going. Think about sleep, food, health, attitude, and people who help.
3. Write each idea on its own line. Which three seem most important? Mark them with a star.
4. Test your list on something real, like a habit you would like to keep going for a month.
5. Share your list with someone and ask, "What did I forget?"

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick just three things a player would need to keep showing up and draw a picture for each.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Sort your ingredients into "things I control" and "things I don't." Which group is bigger? What does that tell you about streaks?

# 🤝 LIFE SKILLS & SEL

*Baseball is a team game, and the best teams know that kind words, safe habits, and a calm mind matter as much as a strong arm.*

## 🗣️ Challenge 1: Words That Pick a Teammate Up

🎯 Encouraging Others

***What can you say in ten seconds that changes how someone feels after a tough moment?*** ❓

Your friend just struck out with the bases loaded, or dropped an easy fly ball, and now they're staring at their shoes. Time to practice being the teammate everyone wants.

1. Grab a partner. One of you plays the player who messed up; the other plays the teammate.
2. Brainstorm 3 things that help ("Shake it off, you've got the next one!") and 2 things that don't ("How did you miss that?!").
3. Act out the scene using only the helpful words. Add a pat on the back or a fist bump.
4. Switch roles and try it again with different words.

Why: When someone feels embarrassed, their body gets tense and their thinking gets cloudy. Kind words help them relax so they can focus on the next play.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use just one sentence you like, such as "Next time!", and say it with a smile.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Write a short script with your partner for three different mistakes (a strikeout, an error, a missed sign), then perform all three for your family.

## 🦺 Challenge 2: Safety Officer on Duty

🎯 Safety Planning

***What would you check before the first pitch so that nobody goes home with an ouch?*** ❓

You're the safety officer for tomorrow's yard or park game, and nobody plays until you approve the field.

1. Walk the play area with a pencil and paper. Look for holes, rocks, sticks, broken glass, and wet or slippery spots. Write down what you find.
2. Decide where everyone should stand, and how far batters must be from other people. Try measuring with big steps or arm-lengths.
3. List the gear everyone needs: gloves that fit, and a helmet for the batter and runners if you have one.
4. Add a rule for each danger, such as "Look before you swing" or "Bat stays down after you hit."
5. Draw a box next to each item and check it off.

Why: Most ball injuries happen when people are too close or not looking, so spacing and a clear field prevent more accidents than any equipment can.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make a checklist with just four items and draw a picture for each one.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Test your checklist at a real park, then fix anything you missed, and ask an adult to give you a safety grade.

## 🧘 Challenge 3: Staying Calm Like a Champion

🎯 Self-Control

***How do you keep your cool when things feel unfair or you really want to quit?*** ❓

Jackie Robinson faced unfair treatment when he joined the major leagues in 1947, yet he kept his focus on playing his best. Staying calm can be learned, and you can find out how the people closest to you do it.

1. Read or listen to a short story about Jackie Robinson, with an adult's help if you need it.
2. Write 3 interview questions, such as "Tell me about a time you stayed calm when it was hard," or "What helps you not lose your temper?"
3. Interview two family members and write down their answers.
4. Add your own: name one time you stayed calm and what you did.
5. Circle the calming tricks you heard (deep breaths, counting, walking away) and pick one to try this week.

Why: Slow breathing tells your body it's safe, which switches off the "fight or run" feeling so you can think clearly.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Ask just one family member one question, and draw their answer.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Interview three people of different ages and compare their calming tricks to find the one that appears most often.

# 🎵 MUSIC

*Baseball has its own soundtrack, from the organ at the ballpark to the stomping and clapping of a cheering crowd.*

## 🎤 Challenge 1: Sing and Clap the Seventh-Inning Song

🎯 Beat and Meter

***Why does a song feel like it sways when you count it in groups of three?*** ❓

Fans have sung "Take Me Out to the Ball Game" together for generations. Let's learn to feel its swaying beat.

1. Sit down and pat your knees in a steady count: ONE-two-three, ONE-two-three. Make the first beat in each group the loudest.
2. Hum the tune while you keep patting. Say the words out loud first if you need to.
3. Now sing the first line, "Take me out to the ball game," landing a pat on each strong beat.
4. Add a clap on the strong beat and a soft knee tap on the other two: CLAP-tap-tap, CLAP-tap-tap.
5. Practice the whole chorus three times, then gather the family and lead everyone in singing and clapping along.

Why: grouping beats in threes gives music a gentle rocking feeling, like a swing going back and forth, and that is why the crowd naturally sways while singing.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the singing at first. Just pat your knees in groups of three while someone else hums the tune.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make up a second verse about your own favorite snack or player, and sing it using the same clap pattern.

## 🥁 Challenge 2: Cheer Captain's Bucket Beat

🎯 Rhythm Patterns

***How can just a clap, a stomp, and an upside-down bucket make a whole crowd move together?*** ❓

You're the cheer captain, and your team needs a chant that makes the stands shake. Time to build one from scratch.

1. Grab a bucket or a big pot and turn it upside down. Tap it with your hands or two wooden spoons.
2. Make three sounds: a CLAP, a STOMP, and a bucket TAP.
3. Mix them into a pattern that is four beats long, like STOMP-STOMP-CLAP-tap. Repeat it until it feels steady.
4. Add a short shout that fits the rhythm, like "Let's go, team!" Fit one word or syllable to each beat.
5. Teach your chant to a friend or family member and cheer together, keeping the pattern going without stopping.

Why: repeating a short pattern makes it easier for a whole crowd to join in, because everyone can predict what comes next.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only two sounds, a clap and a stomp, in a two-beat pattern.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Build a second pattern with different sounds, then switch between the two patterns without losing the beat.